case will be handled by the CBI [Central Bureau of Investigation] without any government interference. I was only explaining why the notion of a presumptive loss was flawed.'

Flawed it may have been, but Sibal should have known that by then the public had made up its mind. He was fighting a losing battle. More so, because none of his ministerial colleagues, including the prime minister, were willing to speak up. In the age of a hyperactive media, the UPA's silence was interpreted as an admission of guilt.

The target of Sibal's ire was not just the media. It was also the CAG. If T.N. Seshan gave an identity to the office of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), Vinod Rai altered the profile of his post from dreary accountant to a robust auditor of policy. Rai, a Kerala cadre IAS officer, had gained a reputation for financial management before he was chosen by the UPA government for the CAG post. 'We scored a self-goal,' one UPA minister said later. 'We never thought someone like him would turn against us in such a public manner.'

Like Anna Hazare, Rai found himself becoming a popular symbol of the war against corruption. After he retired as CAG, I met the silver-haired Rai once on a flight and asked him about his newfound image as an anti-corruption crusader. 'I was only doing my job. I did not seek any media attention,' was his short reply.

Ironically, Rai, like the prime minister, was perceived to be an honest, industrious bureaucrat. Even more ironically, he had been Manmohan Singh's student at the Delhi School of Economics. It had taken one of his own to push Dr Singh's government to the brink. A hostile media, an unyielding judiciary, an empowered CAG—the prime minister was looking like an old man at sea besieged by rapidly rising waves. As the prime minister struggled to rescue his reputation, the one person who could have saved him with a supporting raft was also becoming less visible.

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